How to Connect to the RAGtime MCP Server: A Step-by-Step Guide

"Connecting" to the RAGtime MCP server means giving Claude permission to search RAGtime for you, so you can ask Claude questions and get answers that cite real documents.

Start here: which way should you connect?

Most people at Lawfare should use **Path A**, the Claude website or app. It takes about two minutes and needs no passwords.

If you...	Use	Time
Sign in to Claude with your **Lawfare** account, in a web browser or the Claude app	**Path A**	About 2 minutes
Use **Claude Code**, the version of Claude you type into in a text window on your computer	**Path B**	About 10 minutes, once
Sign in to Claude with a **personal** account, not a Lawfare one	**Path C**	About 3 minutes

Not sure? Start with Path A. If RAGtime is not in your list at step 3, use Path C.

Before you start

You need the items below. You do not need to know how to code.

For Path A (Claude website or app, Lawfare account)

- [ ] You can sign in to Claude with your **Lawfare** email.

For Path B (Claude Code), the above, plus:

- [ ] A Mac or Windows computer you're allowed to install apps on.
- [ ] RAGtime turned on in your Claude account (Path A, steps 1–3).

For Path C (personal account)

- [ ] Any Claude account. A free one works.

Path A: Turn on RAGtime in the Claude website or app

Lawfare's Claude administrator has already added RAGtime for everyone at Lawfare. All you do is switch it on. You never type a password.

1. Go to **claude.ai** and sign in with your Lawfare account.
2. In the sidebar on the left, click **Customize**, then **Connectors**. Or go straight to **claude.ai/customize/connectors**.
3. Find **RAGtime** in the list. It has a **Custom** label. If it says **Connect**, click it. If it already says **Connected**, go to step 4.
4. Start a **new chat**.
5. Click the **+** button at the lower left of the message box, choose **Connectors**, and make sure **RAGtime** is switched on.
6. Ask a test question. See *Check that it worked* below.

The Claude desktop and phone apps use the same account. Once RAGtime is on at claude.ai, it's on in the apps too.

Don't see RAGtime under Connectors? Your account may not be in Lawfare's Claude organization yet. Ask the RAGtime team, who will check with the Claude administrator. Until then, Path C works with any account.

Path B: Use RAGtime in Claude Code

Claude Code is a version of Claude you type into in a text window on your computer. You don't need to be a programmer to use it. RAGtime comes into Claude Code **automatically** from your Claude account, so there is nothing to copy, download or configure, and no password.

One step uses **Terminal** (Mac) or **PowerShell** (Windows), the built-in text-command apps. When a step says "paste this," copy the grey text exactly, paste it, and press **Return** (Mac) or **Enter** (Windows).

- **Open Terminal on a Mac:** press **Command (⌘) + Space**, type **Terminal**, and press **Return**.
- **Open PowerShell on Windows:** click **Start**, type **PowerShell**, and press **Enter**.

One-time setup (about 10 minutes)

1. **Turn RAGtime on in your Claude account first.** Follow Path A, steps 1–3. On a personal account, follow Path C, steps 1–6. Claude Code uses the same account, so this is what makes RAGtime show up there.

2. **Install Claude Code.** Paste the line for your computer:
   - Mac:
     ```
     curl -fsSL https://claude.ai/install.sh | bash
     ```
   - Windows:
     ```
     irm https://claude.ai/install.ps1 | iex
     ```

   When it finishes, close the window and open it again.
3. **Start Claude Code.** Paste `claude` and press Return or Enter.
4. **Sign in.** Claude Code asks how you want to sign in. Choose the option to sign in with your **Claude account** (not an API key). A browser window opens: sign in with the same account you used in step 1 and approve. Then go back to the Terminal or PowerShell window.
5. **Check RAGtime is there.** Type `/mcp` and press Return or Enter. You should see **claude.ai RAGtime** marked as connected. Press **Esc** to close the list.

Every time you want to use RAGtime

1. Open Terminal (Mac) or PowerShell (Windows).
2. Paste `claude` and press Return or Enter.
3. Ask your question. RAGtime is already connected.

To leave Claude Code, type `/exit`.

Path C: Add RAGtime to a personal Claude account

If your Claude account is your own, and not part of Lawfare's Claude organization, you add RAGtime yourself. It needs no password. You get the **free** tools: search, filters and reading documents. The AI tools are not available on a personal account yet.

1. Go to **claude.ai** and sign in.
2. In the sidebar on the left, click **Customize**, then **Connectors**. Or go straight to **claude.ai/customize/connectors**.
3. Click **+**, then **Add custom connector**.
4. Type **RAGtime** as the name. For the address (URL), paste this exactly:
   ```
   https://ragtime-mcp.benjamin-wittes.workers.dev/mcp
   ```
5. If Claude asks how people sign in, choose **No sign-in**. Leave every other setting as it is.
6. Click **Add**.
7. Start a **new chat**. Click the **+** button at the lower left of the message box, choose **Connectors**, and make sure **RAGtime** is switched on.
8. Ask the first test question under *Check that it worked* below.

- Claude may warn you that a custom connector is not verified. That is expected: RAGtime is not in Claude's public directory yet.
- A free Claude account can hold one custom connector.
- Want Claude Code as well? Do steps 1–6 here, then Path B from step 2.

Check that it worked

Ask Claude this:

> Using RAGtime, how many OLC opinions are in the corpus, and what's the date range?

It worked if Claude says it is using a RAGtime tool (you may see a small note such as "get_facets") and answers with a number of opinions and a range of dates. If Claude answers from general knowledge without mentioning RAGtime, see *Troubleshooting* below.

That question only needs a free tool. On Path A or B, check the AI level too:

> Using RAGtime, summarize one OLC opinion about emergency powers.

It worked if Claude uses a tool such as "summarize_document" and answers from the opinion. If Claude says a password or a key is needed, the connector is on but its AI access is not: tell the RAGtime team. On Path C that message is expected.

RAGtime has two levels of tools:

Level	What it does	Examples	Who gets it
Free	Finds and opens documents	Keyword search, filters, fetching a document, reading court filings	Everyone who is connected, on any path
AI	Has RAGtime do the research and write answers	Asking a whole corpus a question, summarizing a document, finding similar documents	Lawfare accounts, on Path A or B. Not personal accounts yet

AI requests come from Lawfare's shared allowance of **5,000 a day**, which resets daily. Paths A and B both draw on it.

Troubleshooting

What you see	What it means	What to do
Claude answers without mentioning RAGtime	RAGtime isn't switched on	Path A or C: click the **+** button by the message box, choose **Connectors**, and switch RAGtime on. Path B: type `/mcp` and check that **claude.ai RAGtime** is connected.
RAGtime isn't listed under **Customize → Connectors**	Your account isn't in Lawfare's Claude organization yet	Ask the RAGtime team. Until then, use Path C.
`/mcp` in Claude Code doesn't list **claude.ai RAGtime**	Claude Code is signed in to a different account, or RAGtime isn't on in your Claude account	Do Path A, steps 1–3 (or Path C, steps 1–6). Then in Claude Code type `/logout`, then `/login`, and sign in with that same account.
AI tools stop working, but search still works	Lawfare's daily AI allowance is used up	Try again tomorrow, or tell the RAGtime team.
Claude says a RAGtime tool needs a password or a key	On a personal account, the AI tools aren't available yet. On a Lawfare account, the connector's AI access is off	Path C: nothing is broken, and search still works. Path A or B: tell the RAGtime team.
"Rate limit exceeded"	Too many RAGtime requests arrived in the same minute, which happens when many people try it at once	Wait a minute and ask again.
Claude can't add or reach the connector (Path C)	The address doesn't match	Remove the connector and add it again. Paste the address exactly; it ends in `/mcp`.
"command not found: claude" (Mac) or **"claude is not recognized"** (Windows)	Claude Code isn't installed, or the window needs reopening	Close and reopen Terminal or PowerShell. If that doesn't help, redo Path B step 2.
A newly added RAGtime collection doesn't appear	Claude loaded RAGtime's old list when the chat started	Start a **new** chat (Path A or C), or quit Claude Code with `/exit` and start it again (Path B).

Directions generated from a Claude Code session and checked against Claude's own documentation on October 1, 2026. Claude's menus change. If a step does not match what you see, use the **Feedback** button at ragtime.lawfaremedia.org and say which step.